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CEAS 395

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A Wesleyan Student's Guide to Fascism: The Case of Modern Japan- Final Paper

At the start of the class, fascism to me was something that was largely, but not strictly, ideological in nature. When I thought about fascism, I thought about political events and political trends. And even though it is traditionally identified by some of the world's most infamous figures, fascism was to a great extent displaced and decentered from the individual, it was a historical phenomenon with a contemporary strand and a movement to be observed like a message in a bottle. Looking at fascism now, however, it is fair to say I have developed a plethora of previously unaccounted-for insights. For example, fascism as an intuition and as an experience- an emphasis on the organic almost spiritual component which lies within. As a direct contrast to my previous understanding of fascism as displaced from the person, fascism is instead highly individualized and relies heavily on the individual and his bursts of violence. Specifically, this sort of violence also diverges greatly from the sweeping eliminationist campaigns of Hitler and Mussolini, and instead stems from an indifference, apathy, and a non-particular hatred toward society at large. It is these kinds of developments which I aim to flesh out in this paper.

A worry I had going into this was that my personal developments on what constituted fascism were actually opposed to what other people reaped from the class. The reason for this, I believe, stems from the logic engaged by Slavoj Zizek in his interview piece with Andrew Herscher, "Everything Provokes Fascism". A big takeaway from this text was that it would be highly unproductive to reduce fascism to a kind of guessing game where people treated it as a

pejorative. The reason for this was the subject of Žižek's critique, the curious case of a Slovenian postpunk band called Laibach which had come under fire for their use of fascist aesthetic. In response to these accusations, Žižek warns that people must not fall into the all-too-common cycle of declaring "superficial phenomena like political movements, demonstrations, and extraordinary circumstances to be fascism" (Herscher, 60). In this case, that would be what happened with Laibach: people hyper fixating on the appearance of symbols, scouring current events for insignias, and looking for surface level comparisons that anyone with the naked eye can see. That all being said, the reason why I felt my personal revelations ran contrary to the idea that fascism was more rather than less specific in its parameters was also because of my analysis of Žižek. As the title suggests, "everything provokes fascism", but the problem is that the Left (what Žižek takes to be fascism's consistent enemy) does not understand how to properly make out "everything" in a critical manner and instead they have taken fascism to be *literally everything*.

With that in mind, what Žižek is trying to get at here is that fascism indeed stems from a very concise materialist framework. The evidence for this lies in his famous description of fascism as "capitalism without capitalism...[the goal is] to preserve the basic relations of capitalism, but simultaneously to take away capitalism's ideological and economic features, which brings individualism, disequilibrium, and so forth" (Herscher, 60). Furthermore, Žižek puts a great deal of stress on the power of ideology. This was the ultimatum of his problem with the Laibach controversy; fascist signifiers with a complete vacancy of the fascist fantasy, and fantasy was at the crux in which the paradoxical undertaking of the fascist mission lay. Laibach was engaging in the arts for the original intended purpose of the arts, "nothing but enjoyment" (Herscher, 68), the abstraction of the individual whose malleable quality and curiosity could

never sustain the fascist desire for negation and obedience. Nevertheless, I also don't believe this point runs counter to what I mentioned in the beginning- the realization that it was only previously that I understood fascism as majorly ideological and specific. To put it another way, my rendering of the fascist model has only grown. The things which I had previously thought about fascism were not necessarily incorrect, but more and more layers have revealed themselves. Case in point, an easily overlooked part of the Zizek piece occurs at the very beginning, right before his breakdown of capitalism and its contradictions, and that is the idea that "fascisms are of different sorts" and it is the capitalism component which unites them (Herscher, 60). This small yet pivotal detail pairs nicely with later parts of the text where Zizek speaks on fascism in a more enigmatic tone. First, there is the way he describes Joze Plecnik, a Slovenian architect who was a major influence on the architecture of Vienna and Prague, as not fascist but that there are "all the roots of a discourse that fascism appropriates without a problem" (Herscher, 62). Second, Zizek reaffirms the Left's own failings by pointing out how obsessed they are with "killing fascism" in order to satiate their "persistent traumatization" (Herscher, 63). He accuses the Left of "persistent impotence" because of their use of "abstractly enlightenment arguments against fascism". Consequently, the Left's generic approach to combating fascism has tended to fixate on its irrational component, yet Zizek calls this a tragedy, that "the more it criticizes those who are caught in fascism, the more it gives them arguments to be fascist." This, I believe, is the fundamental essence of what is meant by provocation and why Zizek claims it to be "everything". It is also why fascism to me has taken this form which resonates with the phrase "the banality of evil." The lesson to be learned is that fascism must not be simplified to mere invective because it will obfuscate all the ways in which it does infiltrate the very facets of life.

What does this look like in practice then? Žižek insisted on the point that enlightenment arguments against fascism are fruitless, and it reminded me of Marilyn Ivy's comments in the foreword of "Fascism, Yet?" The idea of a methodical thread connecting the horrors of Auschwitz all the way back to the Enlightenment project is nothing new. As Ivy mentions in her preface, "in its seeming external negation of liberal, capitalist democracy, fascism in fact completes as its '*internal* negation,' the truth of capitalist democracy" (Ivy, xi). This was the scholarship of critical theorists Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer in *Dialectic of Enlightenment*. In short, their argument was that in its attempt to reify mythology, the Enlightenment actually set off a chain reaction which eventually reverts back to mythology. From there, Ivy underscores how this mode of analysis finds substance in the American culture industry regarding fascism. However, she specifies that when Adorno and Horkheimer were writing on this, they were pointedly commenting on "the virtual fascism of the consumer" as opposed to its other *forms*. Comparing this to Žižek's disclaimer, there is a solid case to understanding fascism as a more entrenched and cryptic problem. Ivy concludes similarly to Žižek, "We are ever naïve if we think of democracy, that is, as the obverse of fascism" (Ivy, xi).

Lending evidence to Japan, one can already assume what is to be a grim reality by following this train of thought. Without a critical understanding, it would be safe to assume that with the end of the second World War, the fascist state had collapsed and democracy had taken its place. On the record, perhaps; Japan did only become its own sovereign country in 1952 evidently after the fall of the Japanese empire in 1945 but also, and this part is often forgotten, after the end of U.S. occupation. In the long expanse that is time, seven years may not appear to be substantial, but throughout the course of human history, it must be insisted that a lot can happen in a short amount of time. This is not to say, however, that whatever implications fascism

has for Japan in the present is only the result of this seven year limbo where fascism proliferated. Instead, it is useful to think about what has happened from then until now using Žižek's language, that the form of fascism has changed and it is of a different sort in the 21st century. The end of the Pacific front did significant damage to the explicitly imperialist image of fascism, weakening but not completely erasing its claims to colonization, interstate conflict, and legitimacy of its holy war narrative. Even so, new specters began to take their place as the world continued to chug forward, and chug forward it did thanks in part to the emergence of neoliberalism. This accelerated neoliberal process by itself also contributed to the intensification of fascist-adjacent movement in a manner not dissimilar to what had happened to imperial Japan in the late 19th century. Ultimately, what has occurred is a fusion of sorts; there are the unaccounted feelings which date back to pre-WWII contexts and have never gained closure, yet simultaneously there are new issues popping up day to day which are equally unsettled. As the Kyoto-trained Tosaka Jun theorizes in his mysterious and momentous piece *On Space*, "Space and time are of different dimensions. They develop and organize the various phenomenal forms. So even if they are made to be two things in parallel one could not paint them with the same brush" (Jun, 23). Moreover, the everyday space which people occupy must not be conflated with the space imagined by the literally "larger than life" machinations of the "Kokutai", the static creed which Jun aimed to criticize. The ongoing ordeal of fascism then is to survive the crucible of time and reanimate that space in changing conditions. To its advantage, modernity persists in all contexts, for that is the age the world continues to operate in. And as a result, fascism continues to run the gauntlet, and although it is forced to take on new forms every now and then to accommodate for this changing meta, the state of our society ensures it is there, somewhere, lingering in the darkness or finally emerging into the light.

What I find to be a perfect encapsulation of this feeling is interestingly, not in the explicit agenda of ideological fascists such as Kita Ikki, but within the anecdotal, off-hand experiences of the everyday person, asides which are found in the short stories of authors who can hardly be considered fascist thinkers. In the pre-war era, this is Natsume Soseki's *Sanshiro*. In the post-war occupation, this is Nosaka Akiyuki's "American Hijiki". In both texts, what you effectively have are two protagonists who are quite simply just trying to "take it all in". Though separated on the time horizon, both the eponymous Sanshiro and the titular Toshio are united by a number of things. Both men are living in a time which immediately succeeds and precedes major upheaval. Sanshiro's story takes place at the turn of the 20th century, following the Meiji Restoration and the Imperial Rescript. He is living in a time of state-led industrialization, symbolized by his observation of the trainlines not only dividing up the streets of Tokyo, but in an unceremonious albeit morbid depiction of a train literally "cutting through" a woman who jumped onto the tracks (Soseki, 44), a signal to the potentially violent consequences of such a sharp divide between the pre-modern and the modern. For Toshio, not one but two earthshattering world events have taken place in the time that Sanshiro lived his fictional life, yet the very point of the modernist critique is that people have not been given the time to process all that has happened. Lending evidence, Toshio is part of the generation whose very lives are split between the destruction as well as the destructive mindset of warfare and then the bureaucratic upkeep of American occupation. As we hear in his inner monologues, "Then, I had been helping the Army shoot back at the Americans. Three months later, I was cleaning up to receive them as guests. The only difference was that work on the gun emplacement got me a loaf of bread, while for labor service after we lost I always got money – one yen fifty sen a day" (Akiyuki, 449). In a less visceral but no less significant comparison to Sanshiro, Toshio also observes an illustrated divide

between the epochs of time, then then versus the now. He states that “once, during the lunch break at the customs house, I went down to the beach. Both the anti-aircraft gun and the radar antenna (it looked like a fish grill) had disappeared without a trace. The only things on the beach were a few dozen concrete pipes, and in the water a line of small warships, American minesweepers cleaning up the mines the Americans themselves had planted” (Akiyuki, 449). The use of visuals by Akiyuki demonstrates a number of things which all border the social commentary on memory and remembrance. It begs the question, how are people supposed to make sense of such a dramatic shift in attitudes, and specifically, when people are being told *how* they should feel about life altering events? On the one hand, there is the will imposed by the military during times of strife and when people are conditioned to see the world in absolutes; it is them versus us. On the other, those enemies are now your benefactors but most importantly, the establishment continues, as it did previously, to patronize you and to inform you what the *correct* way of behaving is. In *American Hijiki*, the possibility of a fatal, fascistic outburst lends itself to people like Toshio’s realization of their material conditions. As previously stated, Toshio recognizes that at least during wartime, he was paid in sustenance, since it was the responsibility of the state to maintain the cogs in its war machine. The end of the war inevitably meant the end of that nationalized responsibility. In *Sanshiro*, the fascist harbinger may appear visibly absent throughout most of the book given its innocent day-to-day demeanor, but it’s a “doomed innocence” and the addition of scenes such as the woman and the train offers credence to its creeping presence. In a scene that continues to haunt me even now, Sanshiro on the train ride to Tokyo meets a mysterious and modestly dressed man who later on is formally reintroduced as Professor Cho Hirota. Initially dismissive of Hirota’s presence, Sanshiro soon finds him to be rather intimidating and can only sit in silence as Hirota imparts his opinion in a manner that is

equally uninterested as it is magnetizing (Soseki, 14). Finally, with an almost oracle-like foresight, Hirota leaves Sanshiro with a few words of wisdom before they meet again in the city, “Japan is going to perish...Even bigger than Japan is the inside of your head. Don’t ever surrender yourself- not to Japan, not to anything. You may think that what you’re doing is for the sake of the nation, but let something take possession of you like that, and all you do is bring it down” (Soseki, 16). On a personal note, this passage solidified Soseki as a figure who resonated with the Austrian-Czech novelist Franz Kafka, whose own short stories and tales (written at approximately the same time as Soseki) revealed a premonitory critique of modern society. Likewise, both men had made great observations of the world they were living in and were disturbed by the direction society was headed. But most importantly for my case, neither of their prophecies were formed in a time of explicit fascism, the first World War had yet to happen, but the signs were discernable. As Zizek might say, a “sort” of fascism, maybe a precursor, had spawned and was festering in the undergrowth, yet to become malignant.

Considering all this, I think it is fair to include in the characterization of fascist desire “frankness.” Echoing Toshio’s remark on life during the war, this frankness is highly relevant when analyzing the whims of the alternative right today. I specifically choose to use the phrase “alternative right” for the reason that since fascism as a thing to follow must change and adapt, so must the name of its followers. What makes the alternative right so special is that it’s a group that can’t really be pinned down to any specific category. They break every possible limit and norm and that is exactly what makes them so dangerous. Their frankness lies in the fact that hardly any of them preach fascism as this grand standing mission with highly specific terms: they don’t call themselves fascists (most of the time), their members can’t be categorized by the previous groupings of the historical Right (socially conservative, traditionalist, older

demographic, outward racial or white supremacism), and a lot of them aren't even politically motivated. For example, in Anne Allison's *Precarious Japan*, we are introduced to a number of the precariat, the precarious proletariat, and *furita*, a term used to depict gig workers who had inconsistent jobs and pay, through journal entries and personal accounts. One of these self-identified *furita* was a thirty-one-year-old man named Akagi Tomohiro who I think falls into the basket of alt right. Not involved in politics himself, Akagi's magnum opus "Hope is War" (2007) is essentially a laying out of his frustrations with the system and the belief that war is the only opportunity for people like him who have nothing (Allison, 60). To me, this is a man who gave into the fatal albeit somewhat materially grounded thoughts that Toshio in *American Hijiki* had. The question remains if whether or not Akagi can be considered a fascist. How about the incident involving Kato Tomohiro, who killed seven in Akihabara? There was no specific group he held any hatred for. In his manifesto he wrote "I've come to hate society and am tired of life. Anyone is OK" (Allison, 63). In a story which does end on a higher note, the comedian Chihara Junior recounts his bleak high school years, where his humdrum lifestyle could have gone in a very different direction as noted by activist Amamiya Karin, that is, an interest in right wing organizations after dabbling in some literature on Adolf Hitler (Allison, 72). The connecting thread amongst all of these is the provocation of a kind of Freudian death drive; the wish to fall into the rightwing pipeline is guided by a social nihilism, the same kind of nihilism which drove Yukio Mishima's *Patriotism* and even why Mishima in this strange post-death avatar state remains a global icon of the far/alt right today. To complicate things more, Mishima's own writing and personal involvement are exactly what I meant by "can't be pinned down" by traditional terms. His adoration for the avant-garde, engagement with cultural polygamy, fascination of the homoerotic, and respect among the student protest movement would have

labeled him a heretic by the old fascist regime, yet heretical in some sense is the perfect way to describe Mishima's flavor of fascism, that as equally an aesthetic critique as it is social or political.

All of this is not to say that I would encourage people to use fascism in a casual manner, but the fact of the matter is that fascism remains a topic of discussion. With the arrival of a second Trump presidency, the fascist apparition is too good an example to pass off, and in many ways Trump does represent a disruption to previous models. His whole story was that he wasn't a well-respected member of the old money Right (he was a reality TV star) and was wildly unpopular within the old Republican party apparatus; he built his own golf club because he wasn't welcome in the pre-existing ones. Yet now, the Trumpian fetish for self-determination as well as the Trumpian command of the party speak for themselves and their efficacy by virtue of his very name and the outcome of the election. In the United States of America, the most powerful nation in the world, the American exception (Tocqueville), and the success story for the democratic experiment, the results are there for everyone to see. Fascism must not be made a cliché, yet it remains a concept which is difficult to overstate.